RIGHT TO INFORMATION ACT, 2005

RTI Online

User Manual

A citizen's guide to filing a request with a Central Government public authority, paying the fee, tracking the reply, and escalating through appeal.

Central Government ministries, departments and public authorities

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1 About this portal

RTI Online lets a citizen of India ask a public authority for information under the Right to Information Act, 2005, and follow that request through to a reply. From one place you can file a request, pay the fee, track progress, escalate through appeals, and reconcile a payment that did not go through.

> **NOTE**
>
> This portal serves **Central Government ministries, departments and public authorities only**. For a State public authority, use that State's own RTI portal, or file physically.

The manual follows the same order as the work itself: decide whether to sign in, file, pay, track, and — if the answer does not come, or does not satisfy — appeal.

2 Do I need an account?

No. Filing does not require signing in. You can complete the form as a guest and receive a registration number at the end.

An account is still worth having. It fills your details in automatically, keeps every request you have filed under **RTI Request History**, and collects notifications as those requests progress. You can sign in with a username and password, or through DigiLocker.

The essentials

Who you can ask	Central Government ministries, departments and public authorities
Account needed to file	No — you can file as a guest
Application fee	₹10 · no fee below the poverty line, with a valid BPL certificate
Length of the request	3,000 characters, plus a PDF attachment if you need more room
Your receipt	The registration number issued when you submit
Reply from the CPIO	Due within 30 days of receipt
First appeal	Within 30 days of the reply, or of the date it was due · no fee

3 Filing an RTI request

1. Choose **RTI Request** in the navigation bar, or **Submit a Request** on the home page.
2. Read the guidelines shown before the form opens, and accept them to continue.
3. Select the ministry or department the question belongs to. If you are unsure, open **Public Authorities** and search — the directory covers every listed Central authority and suggests the closest match.
4. Fill in your details and write your question in the request text box.
5. Enter the security code shown beside the box, then submit.

The request text is limited to **3,000 characters**. If your question needs more room, attach the remaining text as a PDF using the attachment option on the form.

Keep the question specific and factual. A public authority must supply information it already holds; it is not obliged to create new analysis, offer opinions, or answer hypothetical questions.

If you pick the wrong authority, the request is not lost. Under section 6(3) of the Act the Nodal Officer transfers it to the correct Central public authority — electronically where that authority is on this portal, physically otherwise.

Your **registration number is your receipt.** Quote it in every later step.

4 Fees

The application fee is **₹10** for a non-BPL applicant, paid after the first page of the form. Payment modes: internet banking through the SBI payment gateway and associated banks, SBI debit card, Master or Visa credit and debit card, and UPI.

Applicants below the poverty line pay **no fee**, but must attach a valid BPL certificate.

Where supplying the information carries a cost — photocopying, for instance — the CPIO will notify you of an **additional fee**. You will see it under **View Status** and receive an email or SMS alert, and you pay it through the portal before the documents are released.

5 If a payment fails

Money sometimes leaves your account without a registration number appearing.

> **IMPORTANT — DO NOT PAY AGAIN**
>
> The first attempt is usually still being settled. Paying twice creates two records to untangle, and does not speed anything up.

1. Open **Payment Reconciliation** from the navigation bar.
2. Enter the email address you filed with. Add the mobile number if you have it; leave it blank if you are unsure.
3. Enter the security code and submit.
4. On the next screen choose **Check Latest Status** to ask the bank where the payment stands.

You will get one of three answers.

OUTCOME	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT TO DO
Payment confirmed	The fee arrived and a registration number has been generated.	Note the number shown. Nothing further is needed.
Refund initiated	The payment failed. Nothing was filed.	The amount returns to the source account in 5–7 working days. File again whenever you like.
Awaiting bank confirmation	Not yet settled.	Wait. Numbers are generated after the bank scroll is reconciled — 24 to 48 working hours.

If nothing has changed after 48 working hours, contact the helpdesk quoting the **transaction ID** from that screen. Your bank can also be asked directly about a refund.

Common causes of a failed payment: e-commerce transactions disabled on the card, the browser closed mid-transaction, or the session timing out at the bank's page.

6 Tracking a request

Choose **View Status** and enter your registration number together with the email address used when filing. Signed-in users go instead to **RTI Request History**, which lists every request with its current status and the next action due.

Deadlines at a glance

Every stage of a request runs on a clock. These are the limits set by the Act.

STAGE	TIME LIMIT
Reply from the CPIO	**30 days** from receipt
Where the life or liberty of a person is concerned	**48 hours**
Transfer to the correct authority (s. 6(3))	**5 days** the 30-day clock then runs from transfer
Filing a first appeal	**30 days** from the reply, or from the date it was due
First Appellate Authority decision	**30 days** extendable to 45 with recorded reasons
Filing a second appeal	**90 days** from the decision, or from when it was due
Complaint to the Commission (s. 18)	**No time limit**

Timelines are those set by the Right to Information Act, 2005.

7 First appeal

File a first appeal if you are dissatisfied with the reply, or if no reply arrived in time.

1. Choose **First Appeal** in the navigation bar.
2. Enter the registration number of the original request and the email address used to file it.
3. Your details and the authority are filled in from that request; add your grounds for appeal.
4. Submit. You receive a separate appeal registration number.

There is no fee for a first appeal.

Two limits are worth knowing. An online first appeal can only be filed against a request that was itself filed online through this portal. And if your request was physically transferred to an authority that is not on this portal, the appeal must be made to that authority directly.

8 Second appeal and complaints

If the first appeal is decided against you, or is not decided at all, you may appeal to the Central Information Commission within **90 days**.

Separately, a complaint may be made to the Commission under **section 18** — for example where an authority refused to accept your request, or no Public Information Officer was designated. A section 18 complaint has no time limit, and is a different route from an appeal, not a later stage of one.

The escalation path

STEP	WHO DECIDES IT	TIME LIMIT
Request	The CPIO of the public authority	Reply within 30 days
First appeal	The First Appellate Authority	File within 30 days · no fee
Second appeal	The Central Information Commission	File within 90 days
Complaint (s. 18)	The Central Information Commission	No time limit

A section 18 complaint is a separate route, not a stage of the appeal.

9 Notifications

Signed-in users are notified when a request changes state — a reply received, an appeal due, a deadline approaching. The bell in the navigation bar shows the unread count. **All Notifications** lets you filter by read and unread, mark items individually, or clear the list at once.

Providing a mobile number is optional, and is used only for SMS alerts.

10 RTI Sahayak

RTI Sahayak is the assistant in the lower-right corner. It explains the process, helps word a request, and points you at the right public authority from the full directory.

> **WARNING — NEVER SHARE CREDENTIALS IN THE CHAT**
>
> Never type an OTP, Aadhaar number, card number, bank account number, PIN or password into the chat. Messages containing them are refused before they are sent. No genuine officer will ever ask you for these in a chat window.

11 Accessibility

The strip above the navigation bar controls text size. **A+** enlarges the interface, **A−** reduces it, and **A** returns it to normal. The choice is remembered on that device.

12 Getting help

Use **Contact Us** for the helpdesk form, or **FAQs** for the questions asked most often. When writing about a specific request, always quote the registration number — or the transaction ID if the problem is a payment.

DISCLAIMER

This manual describes how to use the portal. It is not legal advice, and does not replace the text of the Right to Information Act, 2005. Timelines are those set by the Act and may be varied by the Commission in a particular case.

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